

Lesson 10: How to Be Loyal to Your Team

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Do you have your employees back? That question could be taken several different ways. Do you mean in a disagreement? With benefits? Or in areas of promotion? In a word, yes. As Pat once said, loyalty is something that must be tended to on a daily basis. It's a bond that must continue to be strengthened throughout the inevitable highs and lows.

But what does that mean specifically? In this lesson, we'll look at some specific ways you can champion your own team members. Think about the last time someone showed you loyalty in a troubled spot. What if you could recreate that feeling in the workplace? Loyalty is something that is caught more than taught, as they say. It's something team members have to feel or experience for themselves, not just something you can verbally tell them is important.

The good news is there are several ways you can begin to show intentional loyalty to your team members. Loyalty can be shown with great benefits, yes. Who doesn't appreciate a great compensation package? But that's not the only way. And it's becoming harder and harder to stand out in the workplace solely with good benefits. We're talking about the unique loyalty you as a leader can model and pass on to your team.

For example:

Viewing everyone as a star player. As Pat once put it, "If you seek out quality people and convince them to be loyal to your organization, you will succeed, but you must be willing to acknowledge their talents and let them do their jobs." This means giving them a level of trust from the beginning as part of the team, not making trust something that starts on zero and has to be earned.

Championing team member growth. Pat did this excellently. She knew how to take underdeveloped, bright young athletes and give them increasing responsibilities. The pathways for growth on her team were clearly outlined. It wasn't a mystery. Team member growth should be a priority, not an afterthought when it comes to cultivating loyal employees. This means being slow to offboard or not overreacting to people's mistakes. Conflicts are going to happen. Mistakes are going to be made. Those times will test your loyalty to your team members. Do you cut the rope and turn them loose? Or do you give them a reasonable time to work on their behavior and correct? Nothing kills loyalty among team members more than watching other team members be axed or terminated for little to no reason.

Finally, recognize your rock stars. This means celebrating wins and looking to catch people doing the right things. The best leaders know to not only do this, but how to do it well. You also

want to look for ways to cultivate an environment where team members are loyal to each other.

For example:

Communicate openly about company goals, challenges, and decisions, creating an environment where employees feel informed and included. When everyone has equal access to the information, it eliminates unnecessary rivalries and pecking orders.

Hold regular team meetings where employees are encouraged to voice their opinions. This keeps things from being bottled and leaking into the gossip mill. It also prevents one employee from having the ear of senior leadership and everyone else feels excluded.

Follow through on your promises. When leaders follow through on their promises, it sets a standard for the entire team. Clearly communicate job duties and roles among the team. Nothing creates contention and disloyalty faster than confusion among who is doing what. If someone has authority in a particular area, make sure the team knows it, rather than refusing to clarify. This can lead to team members thinking leadership has a teacher's pet and can cause disloyalty among your team.

When conflict arises between team members, encourage them to work it out first between themselves before calling in upper management. This puts the responsibility on them for their own interactions and relationships with their team members without leveraging leadership as a referee.

These are just a few things you can do to not only be loyal to your team, but encourage them to be loyal to each other.